"The journey of a thousand miles begins with one step."

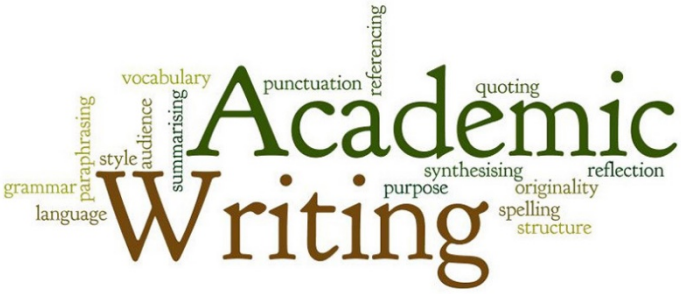
Lao Tzu

ACADEMIC WRITING INTRODUCTION: Academic Vocabulary and Collocations

Developed and compiled by
Michael Warrick

WHAT IS ACADEMIC WRITING?

Find out by doing this short quiz:



1. Compared with other writing, academic writing is:

a) is always highly specialized
b) aims to be precise
c) is difficult to understand

2. Academic writing avoids:

a) slang, contractions, conversational phrases
b) phrases containing many nouns
c) vocabulary and collocations that are more common in writing

3. Which of the following words/expressions is/are not academic?

a) for example
b) issue
c) last but not least

4. When writing an academic text, it is usually advisable to avoid:

a) redundancy / repetition of words or ideas
b) being too brief
c) complexity in the presentation of ideas

5. A topic sentence is normally placed at the:

a) beginning of a paragraph
b) middle of a paragraph
c) end of a paragraph

6. An important purpose of an essay introduction is:

a) to outline the main body
b) to excite the reader
c) to conclude your ideas

7. A collocation is:

a) a combination of words often used together
b) a false idea or belief
c) words that show approval of or admiration for someone/something

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8. The correct format for a citation is:

a) (Jones, 2016)
b) (Tom Jones, 2016)
c) (Jones, T. 2016)

9. The passive is often used in academic English to:

a) give a definition
b) describe process
c) compare and contrast

10. Academic writing is usually:

a) personal
b) impersonal
c) emotional

11. Essay paragraphs should always contain:

a) 7 or more sentences
b) definitions
c) a topic sentence

12. This punctuation mark (:) is called a:

a) full stop
b) colon
c) apostrophe

13. *Progress* and *research* are both nouns. What kind of noun?

a) countable
b) uncountable
c) proper

14. A thesis statement:

a) proposes solutions to a problem
b) outlines the main ideas of an essay
c) concludes an argument in an essay

15. Arguments or opinions are usually supported by:

a) Evidence
b) personal stories
c) vivid descriptions

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2. Which of the questions in the quiz (on the two previous pages) relate to the features of academic writing below?

a) Informal / formal language ……. (3 questions)
b) Concision ……. (1 question)
c) Structure (of an essay) 6, 14 ……. (4 questions in total)
d) Punctuation / grammar ……. (3 questions)
e) Avoiding vague or ambiguous language ……. (1 question)
f) Objectivity (focuses on information rather than people) ……. (2 questions)
g) Using sources ……. (1 question)
h) Words often used together ……. (1 question)

All of the above are important in academic writing. Another important characteristic is *critical thinking*, which refers to the critical analysis of ideas in order to reach a logical decision about the extent to which they are true.

Useful Vocabulary

source (noun) = a text, person or organisation from which information or evidence is obtained

objectivity (noun) = the fact of something being based only on facts or evidence, not on personal feelings; the fact of not being influenced by personal feelings

concise (adj) = giving only the information that is necessary and important, (using few words)

formal (adj) suitable for official or serious situations (usually less common in speech or conversation)

evidence (noun) [U, C] = the facts, data, signs or objects that make you believe that something is true

Oxford Learner's Dictionary of Academic English © Oxford University Press 2014

In general terms, Academic writing is writing which communicates ideas, information and research to the wider academic community. It can be divided into two types: student academic writing, which is used as a form of assessment at university, as well as at schools as preparation for university study; and expert academic writing, which is writing that is intended for publication in an academic journal or book. Both types of academic writing (student and expert) are expected to adhere to the same standards, which can be difficult for students to master.

Adapted from: https://moodle.cornwall.ac.uk/login/index.php

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RESOURCES: WORD LISTS AND DICTIONARIES

THE OXFORD 3000 and OXFORD 5000

What is the Oxford 3000?

The Oxford 3000 is a list of the 3,000 core words that every learner of English needs to know. The words have been chosen based on their frequency in the Oxford English Corpus and relevance to learners of English. Every word is aligned to the CEFR, guiding learners on the words they should know at A1-B2 level. A learner of English with a 6-6.5 IELTS score would need to know all the words in the **Oxford 3000** list.

What is the Oxford 5000?

The **Oxford 5000** is an expanded core word list for advanced learners of English. As well as the Oxford 3000 core word list, it includes an additional 2,000 words that are aligned to the CEFR, guiding advanced learners at B2-C1 level on the most useful high-level words to learn to expand their vocabulary.

What is the CEFR?

CEFR stands for the 'Common European Framework of Reference' for languages, which is a description of the language abilities of students at different levels of learning. The CEFR can be used to compare standards in language learning and create teaching programmes. It grades language skills at six levels:

- A1 and A2 indicate elementary and pre-intermediate levels of ability.
- B1and B2 indicate lower- and upper-intermediate levels.
- C1 indicates advanced level.
- C2 indicates complete proficiency in the language.

USE OF ENGLISH

1. The text on the next page is a paragraph from an academic journal article. **Place the following Oxford 5000 or unclassified words into an appropriate space:**

Oxford 5000 (not including Oxford 3000)

isolation (C1)	flee (C1)	neighbouring (C1)	assumption (B2)
permanently (B2)	migration (C1)	refugee (C1)	pathways (C1)

Unclassified

well-founded	displacement

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The migratory **1.** …… of **2.** refugee contexts are extremely difficult circumstances to navigate. Refugees face geographic change, social **3.** …… and linguistic and cultural shifts associated with their forced **4.** ……. By definition, refugees 5. …… across international borders owing to a **6.** …… fear of persecution (UNHCR, 2010), altering their national and transnational support and communication structures. When settling in camps, refugees can be segregated from national populations and have little financial, legal, or educational support. While some are **7.** …… resettled to countries such as the United States, Canada, and Norway, 86% live in developing countries **8.** …… their countries of origin (UNHCR, 2014). Refugees hope that this **9.** …… is temporary and most international aid, including education, is designed based on this **10.** …….

Adapted from: Dahya & Dryden-Peterson (2017)

2. What do you consider are the number of words from the Oxford 5000 and Oxford 3000 word lists in the above text? **Tick the appropriate box:**

CORE (Oxford 3000 A1to B2)	ADVANCED (Oxford 5000 (B2 to C1 only)	ADVANCED Oxford 5000 (including 3000)	✗✓
12	89	101	
15	70	85	
8	65	73	
13	42	55	

3. Compare your answers with your partner

4. Verify your answers by going to this webpage: https://www.oxfordlearnersdictionaries.com/text-checker/. Cut and paste the above text into the text box and click on the following tabs: i) *check text*, ii) *results* and iii) + *more detail*.

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WORDLISTS AND VOCABULARY REVIEW

1. a) Cut and paste the text below and check You should then find out the proportions of Oxford 3000 and 5000 words.

b) Click on the *activities* tab and then the *filters* tab. Select *B2 (Oxford 5000 excluding 3000), C1, Opal written words* and *unclassified*.

c) Double click on any words within these selections that you do not know and write their definitions at the end of this booklet.

The Grande Cafe (Oxford)

17th Century Coffee and Science

Experimental philosophy came to prominence on a wave of coffee. In the mid-1650s, a group of aspiring Oxford scholars met regularly at a new kind of place. Something like an alcohol-free tavern, it was presided over by an apothecary named Arthur Tillyard. There, spurred by liberal doses of thick, black liquid, they debated the new ideas transforming natural philosophy and the mathematical sciences. This club of scholars moved to London in 1660 and reemerged as what would soon be called the Royal Society. At about the same time, the novel setting in which these rendezvous had originally occurred – the coffeehouse – also moved to London and began an extraordinary surge in popularity there. Together, the coffeehouse and the Royal Society would become perhaps the two most distinctive social spaces of Restoration England. The implications of their advent would stretch beyond England itself. What began in Oxford and London would grow to affect the fortunes of the sciences throughout Western Europe.
(p.320)

Source: Park, K., Daston, L., Lindberg, D.C. & Numbers, R.L. (2006) *The Cambridge history of science. Vol. 3, Early modern science.* Cambridge University Press.

To read more about the **Oxford 3000, Oxford 5000 + other word lists** you can visit the links below:

https://www.oxfordlearnersdictionaries.com/wordlists/

https://www.oxfordlearnersdictionaries.com/definition/academic/obvious

Source: https://www.oxfordlearnersdictionaries.com/wordlists/

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ACADEMIC VOCABULARY (The Academic Word List (AWL)

The Academic Word List (AWL) is a list of non-subject-specific words often found in a range of academic texts. These words occur less frequently in newspapers than in academic textbooks, and even less often in fiction. The list was compiled in 2000 by Averil Coxhead, a lecturer in English for Academic Purposes at Massey University, New Zealand.

These are a few examples:

1. apply
2. significant
3. reveal
4. data
5. level
6. process
7. complex
8. absence
9. reduce
10. theory

Oxford Learner's Dictionary of Academic English Online (1 year's access)

The only learner's dictionary to focus exclusively on academic English, the *Oxford Learner's Dictionary of Academic English* is specifically designed for learners studying, or preparing to study, academic subjects on English-medium university courses.

This online version provides access to the dictionary for 1 year at www.oxfordlearnersdictionaries.com .

Based on the 85-million-word Oxford Corpus of Academic English, it provides all the tools students need to develop their academic writing skills. It includes hundreds of academic usage notes, full-sentence examples based on real academic texts, reference pages, and the Oxford Academic iWriter, an interactive writing tutor.

https://elt.oup.com/catalogue/items/global/dictionaries/9780194724883?cc=global&selLanguage=en

Academic vocabulary beginning with 'a'		Definitions
abundant (adj)	*A -*	1. to make someone/something different; to become different
acknowledge (v)	*B –*	2. to say or believe that something is the result of a particular event or fact
acquire (v)	*C –*	3. a way of doing or thinking about something such as a problem or task
acute (adj)	*D –*	4. to arrive at a particular age, size or level
adequate (adj)	*E –*	5. existing in large quantities; more than enough
adjacent (adj)	*F –*	6. to admit that something is true or exists
alter (v)	*G –*	7. to learn or develop a skill, habit or quality; obtain
amend (v)	*H –*	8. easy to see or understand; obvious
attain (v)	*I –*	9. If a bad situation is ……, it causes serious problems or considerable damage
apparent (adj)	*J –*	10. to change a law, an agreement, etc. slightly to improve or correct it or to reflect changing circumstances
approach (n)	*K –*	11. to imagine or predict that something will happen
assess (v)	*L –*	12. enough in quantity, or good enough in quality, for a particular purpose or need

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associate (v)	*M –*	13. a quality or feature of someone/something
attribute (v)	*N –*	14. to make a connection between people or things
attribute (n)	*O –*	15. next to each other; next to something
anticipate (v)	*P –*	16. to make a judgement about the nature or quality of something/someone

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The words in the table below contain sample words from the AWL. Read the words and note any synonyms you know. **You should then share your suggested answers with your partner:**

Academic vocabulary beginning with 'a'	Synonyms	Academic vocabulary beginning with 'a'	Synonyms
abundant (adj)		*apparent (adj)*	
acknowledge (v)		*approach (n) (to)*	
acquire (v)		*approximation (n)*	
acute (adj)		*assess (v)*	
adequate (adj)		*associate (v)*	
adjacent (adj)		*attribute (n)*	
alter (v)		*attribute (v)*	
amend (v)		*arbitrary (adj)*	
attain (v)		*anticipate (v)*	

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ACADEMIC VOCABULARY IN CONTEXT

1. Find the synonyms in the sentences below for 12 of the academic words from the table (see right). The form of the synonym may differ from the form of the academic word in the table.

Example:

- An essential *characteristic* of a leader is her consistency in applying moral standards to organizational life. ……..

a) A company's good reputation is often linked in the public mind with its trademark. ……..

b) It is widely accepted that the excessive consumption of alcohol can damage health. ……

c) The period from birth to 2 years is a critical time for the development of language and cognition for all children. ……

d) The declining relative wage of blue-collar workers has been ascribed to imports from low-wage countries. …….

e) There is no doubt that memories can be modified by various forms of suggestion. ……

f) In 1913, Henry Ford developed a method of car assembly that involved a chassis moving down an assembly line on a conveyor belt. ……

g) Enormous sizes can be reached by granite boulders which have been moved by glaciers. ……..

h) Locating a health centre next to a school has the advantage of accessibility for students and for community children. ……

i) A rapid increase in students resulted in severe shortages of teachers and textbooks. …….

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j) It is expected that future advances in molecular biology will allow the pathogenesis of the disease to be further understood ……

k) There is ample evidence that immigrants are creating businesses and revitalizing the U.S. workforce (Hesson, 2015).
…….

l) Minor revisions were necessary to some of the supporting documents. ……

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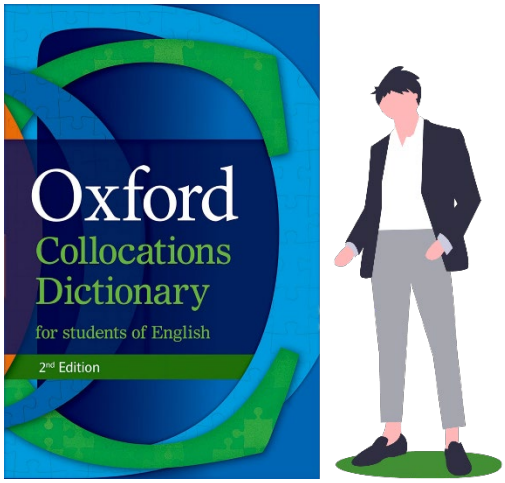
WHAT IS A COLLOCATION?

Write the definition for the term *collocation* here:

……..……..

……..……..



DICTIONARIES

1. The *Oxford Collocations Dictionary* (new edition!) is essential for students, as it can help you to express your ideas naturally in academic writing. You can purchase the dictionary here:

https://www.oxfordlearnersdictionaries.com/definition/collocations/

There is a free version of the first edition at this site, which you can also download:

https://www.freecollocation.com/

2. Academic collocations are also available from ***Pearson's Academic Collocation List*** (ACL), which includes approximately 2,500 collocations that are frequent in academic writing. To download the list, follow the link below:

https://www.pearsonpte.com/teachers/academic-collocation

3. The *Oxford Learner's Dictionary of Academic English* contains both academic vocabulary and collocations.

TYPES OF COLLOCATIONS

Lexical Collocations

English collocations typically follow one of the following six grammatical structures:

adverb + adjective
adjective + noun
noun + noun
verb + noun
verb + adverb
verb + noun

Grammatical Collocations

A **grammatical collocation** is a type of construction where for example a verb or adjective must be followed by a particular preposition, or a noun must be followed by a particular form of the verb, as in:

- **verb + preposition:** depend on
- **adjective + preposition:** afraid of
- **noun + particular form of verb:** strength to lift it
- **verb + verb-ing** = enjoy watching

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ADJECTIVE + NOUN COLLOCATIONS

1. Match the ADJECTIVE + NOUN academic collocations below:

NOUNS	ADJECTIVES
1. STAGE	**a)** criminal · mental · physical · business · commercial · economic · cultural · human · government · economic · innovative · promotional · political · human · daily
2. EVIDENCE	**b)** whole · entire · complex · continuous · dynamic · random · natural · developmental · social · historical · physical/cognitive · biological · chemical
3. FEATURE	**c)** different · alternative · new · fresh · unique · broad · global · international · long-term · theoretical · historical · cultural · social · political · economic · evolutionary
4. PROCESS	**d)** recent · considerable, substantial · increasing · abundant · further · additional · conflicting · strong · good· clear · convincing · compelling · sufficient · insufficient
5. IMPACT	**e)** significant · key · crucial · fundamental · essential · central, principal, main · unusual · distinctive · striking, remarkable · notable · prominent
6. ACTIVITY	**f)** early, initial, preliminary · late · final · latter · advanced · intermediate · various · different · distinct · successive · main · crucial · developmental · larval · embryonic
7. PERSPECTIVE	**g)** significant · major · considerable · profound · dramatic · limited · minimal · potential · positive, beneficial · negative · adverse · detrimental

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COLLOCATIONS WITH *STAGE*

1. Complete the following sentences with a suitable adjective to collocate with *stage*. **More than one answer may be possible:**

a) Welsh cyclist Luke Rowe helped Chris Froome to victory in the …… stage of the Tour de France.

b) In order to be competent speakers of English, learners at an …… stage have to considerably expand their knowledge of vocabulary.

c) The analysis of this data is still at a …… stage and further experimental measurements are planned.

d) Unfortunately, many people do not recognize the …… stage of the ladybird beetle

e) One's educational career is a …… stage of anyone's life.

2. Match the beginnings of the sentences below with appropriate endings:

a) The initial stage… ___
b) At various stages… _v_
c) The most crucial stage… ___
d) In the advanced stages… ___
e) There are three distinct stages… ____
f) During successive stages of development… ____
g) We are in the preliminary stage… ____
h) In the later stages… ____

i. of a project's life cycle is arguably the planning phase.
ii. of the irrigation systems in the Indus valley, little attention was given to land drainage.
iii. of the disease, a significant number of patients require hospitalization.
iv. of life, failing sight may go unnoticed.
v. of the process, changes and revisions may be submitted.
vi. of a successful startup business.
vii. of one of the greatest battles in history.
viii. of a fire is a critical period for firefighting.

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HOMEWORK

COLLOCATIONS: VERB + NOUN / VERB + ADVERB

1. Study the list of selected verbs, showing common noun and adverb collocations:

address: *problem, issue, topic, question, audience, class, person, letter*
analyse: *the data, the evidence, the results* analyse: *closely, in depth, in detail, systematically*
carry out: *an analysis, an assessment, an experiment, an investigation, a survey, a task*
carry out: *fully, systematically*
consider: *the evidence, the options* consider: *carefully, seriously*
deal with: *an issue, a problem, the situation* deal with: *effectively, swiftly*
demonstrate: *the importance (of), the need (for)* demonstrate: *clearly, conclusively*
deny: *the accusation, the allegation* deny: *categorically, strenuously*
discuss: *an idea, an issue, a problem, a question* discuss: *at length, briefly, thoroughly*
establish: *the connection, the relationship (between)* establish: *conclusively, firmly*
examine: *the evidence, the facts* examine: *critically, thoroughly*
identify: *the causes (of), the factors (leading to)* identify: *clearly, straightaway*
raise: *awareness, funds, morale, questions, standards* refer to: *frequently, in passing, obliquely, specifically*
respond to: *an idea, a plan, a proposal* respond to: *favourably, negatively, positively*
result in: *automatically, inevitably*
resolve: *an argument, a conflict, a dispute, an issue, a problem* resolve: *eventually, speedily*
seek: *advice, help, assistance, information, care, treatment, consent, support, asylum*
study: *conclusions, data, results, the situation* study: *closely, in depth, in detail, thoroughly*
suppress: *evidence, personal freedom, protests, a rebellion, social unrest*
suppress: *brutally, ruthlessly*
write: *authoritatively, convincingly, knowledgeably (on)*

2. Complete each sentence with the correct form of one of the following verbs:

Consider suppress raise deny resolve demonstrate seek

a) Narrative structure normally involves some kind of conflict which is eventually …….. at the end of the story.

b) The purpose of the conference was to …..…….. awareness amongst doctors of the pressures on parents caring at home for children with disabilities.

c) Billings (2014) describes how the regime has brutally …..…….. all protests by opposition groups.

d) Dalston's (2012) research conclusively …..…….. that two of the local languages had no written form.

e) Clearly, it cannot …….. that nationalism and national identity invoke powerful emotions for most people.

f) The enquiry panel the ……. evidence carefully over a period of six weeks in early 2009.

g) He arrived in the UK …….. political asylum

Adapted from: Paterson, K. and Wedge, R. (2018) **Oxford Grammar for EAP**. Oxford University Press: Oxford

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RECORDING NEW VOCABULARY

You may use this page to record important new vocabulary:

WORD	WORD FORM	MEANING
Example sentence(s)		
Example sentence(s)		
Example sentence(s)		
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